

Mubina Sadriddinova

Professor Pam Katwal

English 2500

29 September, 2024

Rhetorical Analysis.

Sriram Krishnan, the author of *"You are not imagining it: Social media is in chaos,"* is the general partner at Andreessen Horowitz, a venture capital firm. In his opinion essay, he briefly discusses the role of social media, how the internet works and how we experience it, its improvements, and main ideas by providing information from reliable sources, offering insights about the use of social media, referring to artificial intelligence, and exploring the history of social media. Krishnan talks about how we are entering an age of significant innovation, with more options and influence in managing things online. He maintains hope amidst continual changes and issues. The essay is for people who regularly use social media and online platforms and tech-savvy professionals, social media users, investors, and industry observers. Krishnan conveys that social media platforms are transitioning due to the economic pressures of A.I. and shifting power dynamics between companies and users. He suggests that it may benefit consumers by giving them more control over their online presence in the network.

Krishnan establishes credibility by referencing his opinions as those of an expert in the field. He has worked at large social media companies for the past decade and briefly assisted Elon Musk; as he mentioned, "I briefly helped Elon Musk after he acquired Twitter, in which my firm is an investor." He proves he knows his stuff by discussing his background, work experience, studies, and involvement with major social media companies like Twitter. He uses his experience at Meta

and Twitter to make points based on his knowledge of the factors that affect the tech industry as someone deeply involved in these advancements. His strong presence on social media boosts Krishan's credibility, as he mentioned, **"My firm is also an investor in Substack, Reddit, and other social media companies, and our general partner Marc Andreessen is on the board of Meta."** His connection with well-known companies and his endorsement by Elon Musk, a popular figure on social media, have helped to gain the trust of his audience. By sharing his work on widely used social media platforms, he strengthens the credibility of his message and resonates with his audience's interest in well-informed social media content.

On the other hand, it is noticeable how he argues about the importance of social media in our lives. He believes the online world has stagnated, limited to a few options dominated by large companies. A pessimist might say this will lead to chaos and challenges in eliciting emotional responses from the audience, using real-life examples. His words about the power of users make everyone think more about the power we need; as he said, **"Users and social networks have an unspoken agreement: In return for entertainment, utility, and an audience, users hand over control. You're out in the cold if the network chooses to kick you out. Choosing to leave one platform means losing your audience forever. You can't take it with you."** He hopes that innovative technological solutions will be found to help maintain the open internet and that code, not lawyers, will hold the answers. We will require a radically different mechanism for websites to exchange value A.I. assistants. Otherwise, expect more raised drawbridges and more user protests.

Krishnan critiques social media giants for curating their content in a way that furthers political agendas. The goal of decentralization is to create a network that is credibly neutral in its operations, he said while giving his opinion about C.E.O. **"As interest rates started to rise,**

social media companies discovered they weren't immune to macroeconomic forces. C.E.O.s reacted with an increased emphasis on products that make money directly from the consumer and reduce employees' headcount.". The network should be able to resist attempts by any party to seize power and become centralized. He cites studies from reliable sources, his works, and his company's experience. The logical connection between social media users' power and creators' quality underscores the irony of the pursuit. The author uses these logical points to argue that their modification may give users more power instead of improving social media platforms. Through clear cause-and-effect reasoning, the author presents his thesis. While telling people about the use of A.I. and its use. He briefly gives examples about the A.I. and that it usually does not do what it needs to. A.I. can take some information from reliable sources but never will give the source of the information it is giving. He gives examples: *"So if you ask an A.I. assistant for the names of San Francisco's best restaurants, it could use that Reddit discussion to generate its answer. But it won't tell you that Reddit was a source for its answer. It won't send you to Reddit. And as of now, it pays Reddit nothing for the help."* This information gives the audience the main idea of what Krishnan discusses in his opinion essay.

The fast evolution of social media platforms is a crucial moment in the history of the internet. The text shows a shift towards providing detailed information and giving users more power, which could change the online landscape. The ongoing changes indicate a rejection of the long-standing control by a few large corporations, suggesting a move towards more consumer freedom. This aligns with the essay's main point, indicating that the competition among tech giants is not just about profit or control but about fundamentally changing how the internet works. The body paragraphs give important examples, such as Meta's introduction of Threads, the Reddit protest, and Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter. These examples show a broader

rejection of the current situation and demonstrate the changing power dynamics between users and platforms. The examples show how people's dissatisfaction with centralized control leads to technological and social change. Each example directly relates to the essay's main idea by demonstrating how different strategies, from charging more for data to exploring decentralized platforms, are all attempts to regain control in a new Internet era. This supports the essay's main point, suggesting that the competition among tech giants is not just about profit or control but is fundamentally reshaping how the internet operates. The body paragraphs outline important examples such as Meta's introduction of Threads, the Reddit protest, and Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter. These examples signal a broader rejection of the status quo and show the changing power dynamics between users and platforms. They illustrate how consumer dissatisfaction with centralized control prompts technological and social change. Each example directly ties back to the main idea by showing how various strategies, from charging more for data to exploring decentralized platforms, are all attempts to regain control in a new Internet era. This aligns with the essay's main point, suggesting that the competition among tech giants is not solely about profit or control but fundamentally reshaping how the internet operates. The body paragraphs outline vital examples such as Meta's introduction of Threads, the Reddit protest, and Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter. These examples signal a broader rejection of the status quo and showcase the shifting power dynamics between users and platforms. They illustrate how consumer dissatisfaction with centralized control prompts technological and social change. Each example directly relates to the thesis by demonstrating various strategies, from charging more for data to exploring decentralized platforms., are all attempts to regain control in a new Internet era.

The essay effectively shows that decentralization is becoming more popular as a solution to concerns about censorship, user autonomy, and the dominant power of large platforms. By using

historical examples and current events, the text makes a strong case for why the changes happening in social media are both necessary and unavoidable. It's effective because it combines personal experience with broader industry trends, giving real-life examples—and systematic analysis. Considering the bigger picture, this essay goes beyond social media. It discusses the future of digital communication, user rights, and technological innovation. Artificial intelligence is changing how data is used and platforms deal with decentralized models. This moment could lead to significant changes in how the internet works. We don't know yet if this change will make systems more democratic and open or if it will cause chaos. However, the battle for control over the internet is just beginning.

MLA Citation

Krishnan, Sriram. “Opinion | You’re Not Imagining It: Social Media Is in Chaos.” *The New York Times*, 15 July 2023, www.nytimes.com/2023/07/15/opinion/social-media-threads-twitter-reddit.html.

Mickle, Tripp. “Tech’s Biggest Companies Are Sending Worrying Signals about the Economy.” *The New York Times*, 26 Oct. 2022, www.nytimes.com/2022/10/26/technology/economy-facebook-google.html.

Wagner, Kurt. “It’s Getting Harder and Harder to Tell Instagram, Facebook, Snapchat and Twitter Apart.” *Vox*, 4 Apr. 2017, www.vox.com/2017/4/4/15168010/social-media-facebook-instagram-snapchat-twitter-live-stories-apps-copying